

PTR SHEET - Articles

TOPIC NO: 1.01

SESSION CODE: S1-G1

✓ What is an article?

- ✓ Basically, articles modify nouns, like adjectives do.
- ✓ English has two articles: **the** and **a/an**. **The** is used to refer to specific or particular nouns; **a/an** is used to modify non-specific or non-particular nouns.
- ✓ **Articles** are either *definite* or *indefinite*. They combine with a noun to indicate the type of reference being made by the noun.
 - The **definite** article is **the**.
 - The **indefinite** article is **a / an**.

✓ Uses of the indefinite article **a** or **an**:

The article **a / an** is used when we don't specify the things or people we are talking about:

- I met **a** friend.
- I borrowed **a** pencil from **a** passenger sitting next to me.

The indefinite article **a** is used before a consonant sound:

- **a** dog
- **a** pilot
- **a** teacher
- **a unit** (vowel /u:/ is pronounced as a consonant sound /j/)
- **a university** (vowel /u:/ is pronounced as a consonant sound /j/)

The indefinite article **an** is used before a vowel sound:

- **an** engineer.
- **an** honor (h is silent)
- **an** hour (h is silent)
- **an** elephant.
- **an** athlete

✓ Uses of the definite article **the**:

It's used when the speaker talks about a specific object that both the person speaking and the listener know.

- **The** car over there is fast.
- **The** president of the United States is giving a speech tonight.

When we speak of something or someone for the first time we use **a** or **an**, the next time we repeat that object we use the definite article **the**.

- I live in **a** house. **The** house is quite old and has four bedrooms.
- I ate in **a** Chinese restaurant. **The** restaurant was very good.

✓ **Ø/ zero article (represented by the symbol Ø):**

1. Do not use an article with countries, states, counties or provinces, lakes and mountains except when the country is a collection of states such as "**The** United States" -

- She lives in **France**.
- They live in **Manipur**.
- They climbed **Mount Everest**.

2. Do not normally use an article with plurals and uncountable nouns to talk about things in general-

- He writes books.
- She likes sweets.
- Do you like rock music?
- She ate bread with butter in the morning.

✓ **Some Confusion Regarding Articles with Countable and uncountable nouns**

The can be used with *uncountable* nouns, or the article can be dropped entirely as mentioned above. Consider the following examples:

1. "The two countries reached **the** peace after a long disastrous war" (some specific peace treaty) or "The two countries reached peace after a long disastrous war" (any peace).
2. "He drank **the** water" (some specific water- for example, the water his son brought him from the kitchen) or "He drank water." (any water)

a/an can be used only with *countable* nouns.

1. I'd like **a** piece of cake.
2. I lent him **a** book.
3. I drank **a** cup of tea.